



Crowds contrast: As Punjab fans filled the stadium with energy, Jaipur's inadequate facilities left Dronacharya awardees watching from afar — or not at all. REUTERS & SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Starting strong

Punjab Kings has been part of the IPL since its inception but has yet to win a title. For most seasons, the team has hovered around mid-table, reaching the final only once, in 2014, where it lost to KKR. This year, however, it has started strong with five wins out of eight, playing entertaining cricket under new captain Shreyas Iyer.

The Diary notes that, like RCB fans, Punjab Kings supporters stay loyal as long as the team keeps things exciting — title or not.

This year, as the Diary walked up to the newly built Maharaja Yadavindra Singh Stadium in New Chandigarh, the air was filled with anticipation among home supporters in Punjab jerseys.

Even with KKR's star-studded lineup featuring Andre Russell, Sunil Narine, Ajinkya Rahane, and local

boy Ramandeep Singh, the crowd stayed focused on the young Punjab side, cheering for every boundary and falling silent after each wicket.

The atmosphere shifted when PBKS was bundled out for 111. But Yuzvendra Chahal's spell of 4 for 28 reignited the crowd's passion. The stadium roared as Punjab's bowlers fought back. And when Marco Jansen took the final wicket, the fans erupted in ecstasy.

Sahil Mathur

A farce

At the Sawai Mansingh Stadium before Rajasthan Royals' game against Lucknow Super Giants, empty chairs on the terraces of the RCA Academy and Khel Bhawan were noticeable. In response to rising demand for tickets, the Rajasthan State Sports Council had set up special seating for

Dronacharya awardees and other sporting dignitaries.

What began as a gesture to honour local sports icons quickly turned into an embarrassment. The temporary seating lacked the most basic amenities — no refreshments, no drinking water, not even proper lighting. The terrace was left in complete darkness.

As temperatures soared, the stands remained empty. A few policemen hung around, hoping to catch a glimpse of the cricketers.

"It's a temporary arrangement. If it's successful, we'll consider making it permanent. The idea was to increase the stadium's seating capacity," said Neeraj K. Pawan, president of the Sports Council, at the launch of the initiative. Despite the good intentions, the lack of basic facilities led to a disappointing turnout.

Shayan Acharya